UTTAR PRADESH

SHUTTING THE REVOLVING DOOR

By Prashant Srivastava

On February 22, all the talk in Lucknow was about how '*UP ke do ladke*' (the two boys from Uttar Pradesh, Rahul Gandhi and Akhilesh Yadav) had come together again, sealing the alliance for the Congress and Samajwadi Party in the coming Lok Sabha election. The celebrations were short-lived, though, as a reality check presented itself on February 27 with the Rajya Sabha election. Even as voting was under way, five SP legislators, including the party's chief whip Manoj Kumar Pandey, went to meet Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath. By evening, it was clear that seven party MLAs had cross-voted (one more abstained), dashing the SP's chances on what was a sure third seat from the state.

The RS poll was no sidelight intruding upon the main event: it had been one of the key considerations in the formation of the alliance in UP. Altogether, 10 seats were at stake, with 37 votes needed to win a seat. The BJP had nominated Sanjay Seth as its eighth candidate at the eleventh hour to spite the SP, who had already declared Jaya Bachchan, Ramji Lal Suman and former chief secretary Alok Ranjan as its candidates. The SP needed 111 votes to win all three seats but had only 108 of its own. So, the two votes from the Congress and one vote from Pallavi Patel (Apna Dal Kamerawadi leader) were crucial. In the end, it didn't matter as the SP's own MLAs did it in, and Ranjan lost.

The alliance will now have to quickly regroup after the RS disappointment. According to the agreement, the Congress has been allotted 17 seats in UP, while in Madhya Pradesh, the SP will contest the Khajuraho seat and support the Grand Old Party in the remaining 28 in the state. In UP, the big seats the Congress will be contesting are Rae Bareli, Amethi, Kanpur, Prayagraj, Varanasi and Mathura.

Sources say fear of a split in the minority votes (almost 19 per cent of the population) was also a big factor in the coming together of both parties. The SP was vulnerable because the general consensus is that the Muslim community has come to repose faith in the Congress nationally. Rahul's Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra also got a very good response in the Muslim-dominated areas in UP,

The SP-Congress have a tricky task: forge a 'PDA' front of OBCs, Dalits, minorities while avoiding any negative tag



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which increased the pressure on the SP.

In the past month, questions had been being raised about whether the I.N.D.I.A. bloc will hold. After the MP assembly election debacle, words were exchanged between the SP and the Congress, with allegations that the latter was trying to expand the space for Rahul at the cost of its allies. To assuage such fears, the Congress national leadership apparently impressed on its state unit to settle for 17 seats (they had been adamant on another five—Lakhimpur Kheri , Shravasti, Ballia, Bijnor and Moradabad). The party's UP in-charge Avinash Pandey told INDIA TODAY that some negotiations could happen later but, as of now, "we have